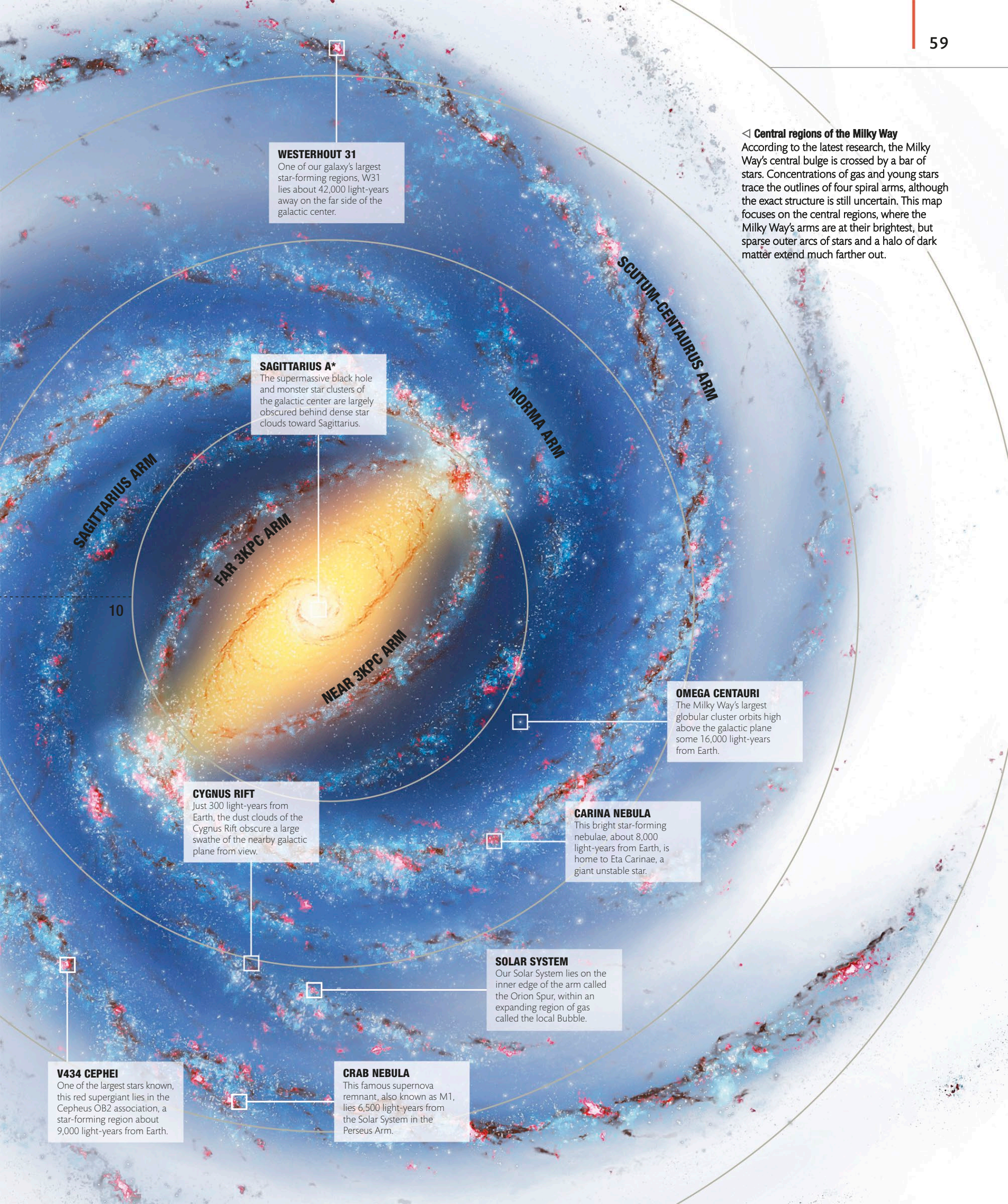


**WESTERHOUT 31**

One of our galaxy's largest star-forming regions, W31 lies about 42,000 light-years away on the far side of the galactic center.

SAGITTARIUS A*

The supermassive black hole and monster star clusters of the galactic center are largely obscured behind dense star clouds toward Sagittarius.

Central regions of the Milky Way

According to the latest research, the Milky Way's central bulge is crossed by a bar of stars. Concentrations of gas and young stars trace the outlines of four spiral arms, although the exact structure is still uncertain. This map focuses on the central regions, where the Milky Way's arms are at their brightest, but sparse outer arcs of stars and a halo of dark matter extend much farther out.

SCUTUM-CENTAURUS ARM

NORMA ARM

SAGITTARIUS ARM

FAR 3KPC ARM

NEAR 3KPC ARM

10

OMEGA CENTAURI

The Milky Way's largest globular cluster orbits high above the galactic plane some 16,000 light-years from Earth.

CARINA NEBULA

This bright star-forming nebulae, about 8,000 light-years from Earth, is home to Eta Carinae, a giant unstable star.

CYGNUS RIFT

Just 300 light-years from Earth, the dust clouds of the Cygnus Rift obscure a large swathe of the nearby galactic plane from view.

SOLAR SYSTEM

Our Solar System lies on the inner edge of the arm called the Orion Spur, within an expanding region of gas called the local Bubble.

V434 CEPHEI

One of the largest stars known, this red supergiant lies in the Cepheus OB2 association, a star-forming region about 9,000 light-years from Earth.

CRAB NEBULA

This famous supernova remnant, also known as M1, lies 6,500 light-years from the Solar System in the Perseus Arm.